

100 Days of Linux - Day 022

Title: Finding Files Quickly with locate

Today's Goal

Learn how to use the **locate** command and understand how it differs from **find**.

Why This Matters

The locate command can find files almost instantly because it searches an indexed database instead of scanning the filesystem.

Command of the Day: locate

Syntax: locate filename

Examples:

locate notes.txt

locate '*.txt'

updatedb (refresh the locate database, if available)

Explanation: Searches a prebuilt database of file paths. Some WSL installations may not have locate installed by default.

Beginner Lesson

Unlike **find**, which searches the filesystem in real time, **locate** searches a database. This makes it much faster, but newly created files may not appear until the database is updated. If your WSL system doesn't have **locate**, note the error and continue with the lesson.

Practice Questions

1. Check whether the locate command is available by running 'locate --version' or 'locate notes.txt'.
2. Create a file named sample.txt and try locating it with locate. If it isn't found, explain why.
3. Use find to locate sample.txt and compare the result with locate.
4. If locate is available, run updatedb (if permitted) and try locating sample.txt again.
5. Display your current working directory after completing today's tasks.

Hints

Remember that locate may not be installed on every WSL system. That's normal. Use find as a comparison.

Mini Challenge

Create three text files in different folders. Try locating them with both find and locate. Write down which command was faster and why.

Common Mistakes

Assuming locate always shows newly created files immediately. It depends on its database.

Did You Know?

Many Linux distributions install locate separately through the mlocate or plocate package.

Pro Tip

Use find when you need guaranteed up-to-date results. Use locate when you need speed and the database is available.

Answer Key (Instructor Only)

Q1: locate --version (or locate notes.txt)

Q2: touch sample.txt then locate sample.txt

Q3: find . -name "sample.txt"

Q4: sudo updatedb (if available) then locate sample.txt

Q5: pwd

Homework

Research whether your WSL distribution uses mlocate or plocate and note your findings.

Next Day Preview

Tomorrow you'll learn grep to search for text inside files, one of the most important Linux commands.